Montagu and Chelmsford had always been slightly strained. The secretary of state believed the viceroy was ‘cold, aloof and reserved’, describing him once as ‘rather sloppy ice’.[91] For his part, Chelmsford often struggled to understand Montagu’s erratic and depressive temperament.[92] As he explained to the secretary of state in 1918: ‘We are built on different lines; you are full of imagination and impulse, I am prosaic and cautious.’[93] During their correspondence, Montagu would often complain of the misunderstandings and apparent lack of affinity between himself and his viceroy.[94] By 1921, this contrast in temperaments had led to such a deterioration in their relationship that Montagu was relieved to have Reading heading out to India in Chelmsford’s place.[95]

Unfortunately for Chelmsford, Montagu was apparently not the only one to be happy at his leaving office. Among the population of India, the viceroy seems to have been generally unpopular.[96] The Indian commentator, Akshaya K. Ghose, for example, delivered a scathing attack upon him at the time of his retirement: ‘A weak, tactless and incompetent ruler – for that is the verdict of History – Lord Chelmsford leaves India in April 1921. India will breathe a sigh of relief!’[97] Another (slightly more generous) contemporary believed that ‘Chelmsford’s lack of ideas of his own, his sound if cautious judgement, his coolness in all circumstances and his respect for orderly administration, contrasted sharply with Montagu’s under-disciplined initiatives and constant state of excitement’.[98]

Yet the criticisms made of Chelmsford have often been contradictory. On the one hand, he is portrayed as a lack lustre viceroy – weak and unimaginative and dominated by his council. Some have described Chelmsford as a ‘mediocrity’, for instance,[99] while others have categorised him as merely an administrator and an agent rather than a policy maker.[100] Reading was also inclined to believe that Chelmsford ‘was too disposed to tread conventional lines and was apparently apprehensive of any action for which there was no precedent...’[101] On the other hand, he was also blamed by some for all of the trouble to have beset India in this period, and for the violence and acts of repression that occurred during his tenure as viceroy. Thus, although apparently ruled by his council, it is Chelmsford that takes the fall for all of the Indian government’s failures in these years – and is given no credit for its successes.